Soumitra Shukla

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Education

Yale University **2015 – 2021**
Ph.D. in Economics (with Distinction) *New Haven, CT*

Yale University **2015 – 2017**
M.Phil. in Economics (with Distinction) *New Haven, CT*

University of Minnesota **2010 – 2015**
B.S. in Economics and Mathematics (with Distinction) *Minneapolis, MN*

Doctoral Qualifying Exams

Labor Economics (with Distinction) and Industrial Organization

Fields of Concentration

- Labor Economics, Organizational Economics, and Personnel Economics

Current Employment

- Research Fellow, Harvard Business School, (Incoming)
- Consultant, The Burning Glass Institute, (Incoming)

Current Affiliations

- Research Affiliate, Department of Economics, Yale University, 2021–present

Past Employment

- Economist, Federal Reserve Board, 2021–2024

Working Papers

- **Making the Elite: Class Discrimination at Multinationals**

  How salient is hiring discrimination in driving socioeconomic gaps in elite job access, and where do these disparities emerge? Measuring class-based discrimination is challenging, especially in Western contexts where status is often inferred from subtle markers such as accent, education, or networks. India's caste system offers a uniquely explicit measure of social class, enabling precise identification of how social status affects access to elite positions. Analyzing detailed screening data from over 1,000 jobs at US and European multinationals in India, this paper provides the first systematic quantification of class bias in elite recruitment, demonstrating that subjective personal interviews assessing candidate "fit" drive nearly 90 percent of caste-based hiring disparities. However, hired disadvantaged castes have around 20 percent higher promotion rates, even in highly selective roles, indicating these disparities cannot be justified by differences in candidate quality. To formally distinguish discrimination from unobserved ability differences, I develop a novel theoretical framework utilizing plausibly exogenous variations in job selectivity, which I empirically test using promotion data. Consistently higher promotion rates among disadvantaged hires across selectivity tiers support the theory's prediction of systematic caste-based differences in hiring thresholds rather than unobserved ability. Given these persistent promotion advantages and the fact that roles are predominantly non-customer-facing, results suggest bias rather than statistical or customer-driven discrimination. These findings highlight a critical organizational challenge: preserving necessary screening discretion without reinforcing class biases that hinder diversity and efficient talent allocation.

- **Interviews**, with Jason Sockin and Elliott Ash

  Interviews allow employers to learn about workers, but do they also enable workers to learn about firms? Using data on hundreds of thousands of interview reports from Glassdoor, we find that candidates for high-paying jobs are 9 percent more likely to reject a job offer if they believe the interview was easy. Easy interviews appear to convey poor "fit" as those who accept offers after easy interviews are one-half of a standard deviation less satisfied with their jobs

and 14 percent less likely to remain with their employer for at least one year. Analysis of interview narratives using a large language model reveals that difficult interviews signal colleague ability and opportunities for skill development, whereas easy interviews convey a nonselective process. Interviews offer workers a preview of match quality, highlighting a unique channel through which labor markets may become less efficient if firms fully automate their hiring processes with AI.

- **Personality and Professional Pathways: Socioemotional Predictors of Success in an Elite MBA Program**, with John Eric Humphries

  This paper provides new evidence on how socioemotional skills shape key outcomes at an elite U.S. business school, with important implications for academic and career success. Socioemotional skills like compassion, gregariousness, and assertiveness are assessed using forced-choice methods that prevent "gaming." The paper examines how these skills influence academic performance, job search behavior, and job offer industry and compensation. The findings are threefold: First, socioemotional skills often outpredict the effects of standardized test scores. Second, the relative importance of different skills varies across academic and career outcomes. Third, these skills operate through distinct channels—for example, while both industriousness and gregariousness predict higher compensation, industriousness is more strongly linked to academic performance, while gregariousness drives job search intensity. These results offer new evidence on how personality influences specialization, job outcomes, and compensation, with important implications for talent management and career development.

Fellowships, Honors and Awards

- University Dissertation Fellowship, Yale University, 2020–2021
- University Fellowship, Yale University, 2015–2020
- Carl Arvid Anderson Prize Fellowship, Yale University, 2019–2020
- Cowles Foundation Fellowship, Yale University, 2015–2019
- Economic Growth Center Prize, Yale University, 2015–2020
- Raymond Powell Prize (for teaching), Yale University, 2018–2019
- Lester Page Hoole Fellow, Yale University, 2017–2018
- Distinction in the Labor Economics Oral Qualifying Exam, Yale University, 2017
- Ella Thorp Scholarship, University of Minnesota, 2014–2015
- Linda and Ted Johnson Research Fellowship, University of Minnesota, 2014–2015
- Phi Beta Kappa (top 2% of class), University of Minnesota, 2014
- Phi Kappa Phi (top 5% of class), University of Minnesota, 2014
- Talle Family Scholarship, University of Minnesota, 2013–2014
- Stockman Scholarship, University of Minnesota, 2012–13
- Undergraduate Research Opportunities Award, University of Minnesota, 2012
- Meritorious Winner: Mathematical Contest in Modeling, University of Minnesota, 2012
- University Honors Program, University of Minnesota, 2011

Research Grants

- Cowles Foundation Research Grant, 2017–2021

Invited Conferences and Talks

- 2025: MIT, NBER Race and Stratification Conference, NBER Organizational Economics, NBER Economics of Culture and Institutions, NBER Summer Institute (Personnel Economics), NBER Summer Institute (Labor Studies)
- 2024: System Equitable Growth Conference, Society for Institutional and Organizational Economics (University of Chicago), NBER Summer Institute (Personnel Economics), People and Organizations Conference (Wharton), NBER Economics of Mobility Conference, NBER Organizational Economics
- 2023: Discrimination in the 21st Century: Fostering Conversations Across Fields (Chicago Booth and the Becker-Friedman Institute for Economics), NBER Economics of Mobility Conference
- 2022: Discrimination and Disparities Seminar, Discrimination in the 21st Century: Fostering Conversations Across Fields (Chicago Booth and the Becker-Friedman Institute for Economics)
- 2021: Wharton (Business Economics and Public Policy), Penn State (Economics of Education Seminar)

Journal Refereeing & Grant Reviews

Quarterly Journal of Economics, Journal of Political Economy, Economics Letters, National Science Foundation, American Economic Journal: Applied Economics

Programming Skills

- R (advanced), Julia (advanced), STATA (intermediate), Python (beginner)

References

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